



PAKISTAN

Capital city: Islamabad
Area: 310,401 sq miles (803,940 sq km)
Population: 154,000,000
Official language: Urdu
Major religions: Muslim 97%, other 3%
Government: Multi-party democracy
Currency: Pakistani rupee
Adult literacy rate: 44%
Life expectancy: 64 years
People per doctor: 1,436
Televisions: 88 per 1,000 people

PAKISTAN

PAKISTAN WAS CREATED IN 1947 as a home for Muslims in India. The country was originally divided into East and West, but in 1971 East Pakistan broke away to become Bangladesh, and West Pakistan became Pakistan. Today, most people make their living from farming, but industry, especially cotton and textiles, is growing steadily. Handicrafts, such as carpet making and metalwork, are also important. Since Pakistan became independent, it has been in dispute with India over the largely Muslim state of Kashmir, which forms part of India, but is claimed by Pakistan.



WATERING THE LAND

The flat, fertile plains of the Punjab form the farming heartland of Pakistan. The rich soil is watered by the Indus River, which also provides water for drinking and for electricity. The river has five tributaries, the Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Sutlej, and Beas, which give the region its name – Punjab means “five waters.” In other parts of the country, huge irrigation (watering) programs have converted scrubland and semidesert into fertile farmland.



PEOPLES OF PAKISTAN

There are many different groups of people living in Pakistan, all of whom have their own distinctive language and culture. The Pathan tribes of the Northwest Frontier are known for their fierce loyalty to family and tribe. The Sindhis (above) are a farming community living in the south of the country with a rich tradition in literature and music. The Punjabis live in the fertile plains of the Punjab.

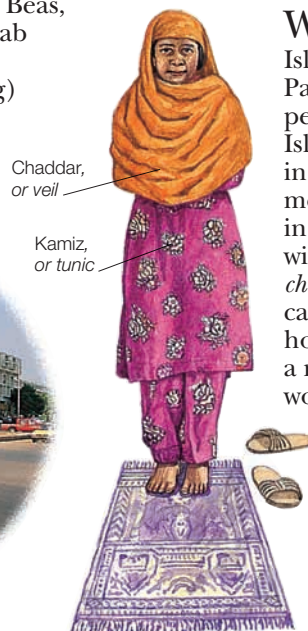


BRIGHT BUSES

Many people in Pakistan travel on the brightly colored buses that run between the towns and cities. The buses often have flowers and patterns painted on them and are decorated with tinsel and lights. Trucks used to transport all kinds of goods are also often highly decorated.

WOMEN'S LIFE

Islamic law is very important in Pakistan. It determines how people worship and behave. It is Islamic custom for women to live in *purdah* (behind the veil). This means that when women appear in public, they cover themselves with a *burqa* (hooded gown) or a *chaddar* (veil) to ensure that men cannot see their faces. Traditional households are often divided into a men's section at the front and a women's section at the back.



- major cities
- irrigated land

WHERE PEOPLE LIVE

The population of Pakistan is unevenly distributed. More than 80 percent of the people live in the provinces of Punjab and Sind, on the fertile floodplains of the rivers.

ISLAMABAD

About a third of Pakistani people live in cities. The capital is Islamabad (right), a brand new city built in the early 1960s. The name Islamabad means the “place of Islam.” The city is well planned, with lots of open spaces and wide, tree-lined avenues. Karachi is the major port and largest city, with around 10 million people.

Find out more

COTTON: 36, 215, 116
IRRIGATION: 155, 156, 217
ISLAM: 275
RIVER VALLEYS: 135